

CLOSING IN ON THE TIGERS

The Sri Lankan Army's plan is to first wrest control over Kilinochchi, the LTTE HQ, even as it begins cutting off supplies to Mullaittivu

MILITARY BALANCE

SRI LANKAN ARMY: With five Divisions as its striking force, the army vastly outnumbers and outguns the Tigers but has chosen to keep its casualties low.

LTTE: Having lost the East, where it used to recruit most of its cadres from, the LTTE is down to 5,000 hardcore fighters. But is capable of stiff resistance.

FIRE POWER

	SRI LANKA*	LTTE
Soldiers	30,000	5,000
Tanks	200	-
Artillery guns	400	60
Attack aircraft	60	3*
Fast-attack vessels	40	30*

* Only for Divisions operating in the battle zone.

- Area freed from LTTE control since 2005
- Areas that still remain under LTTE control in 2008



THE STRATEGY

The Sri Lankan army is engaging the LTTE on a wide front in both Kilinochchi and Mullaittivu districts. Their plan is to clear the jungles of Wanni rather than occupy the main highways.

THE HURDLES

With the north-eastern monsoon settling over the Northern province it has slowed the momentum of the war. Also, the progress is slow for the Sri Lankan Army because it wants to minimise casualties—both its own and that of civilians.



PRABHAKARAN

The LTTE chief is believed to be on the run constantly. Is holed up in the jungles of Puthukkudiyiruppu, close to Mullaittivu. He is using civilians as a human shield and to hide among them.

Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY